approached, we were ushered into the inner cordon and escorted deftly to Rahul Gandhi's side. On seeing us, he immediately greeted us warmly, held our hands and started walking and talking. However, he soon noticed that I (Mridula) was having some difficulty walking fast to keep pace with him. He stopped, got some water for me and told his aides to take us to the sweet shop a few kilometres ahead in Khanna, where they were going to stop for tea. We were so touched by his concern and kindness.

When we reached the teashop after negotiating the crowds, he was already there. He was courtesy personified. He made place for us at the table where all the Punjab Congress leaders and his associates were sitting, and after ordering tea for us started a serious conversation that lasted about half an hour and ended only when he was repeatedly told by his team that they were getting late for the next programme. We were impressed with how focused and attentive he was, despite it being towards the end of a long and physically challenging day. When I (Mridula) said to him that when the Yatra started, it was like a ray of sunlight in a dark sky but now the whole sky seemed full of light, his reply was typically modest and precise. 'Not quite,' he said, 'not yet.' We pointed out how the impact of movements is not measured in terms of immediate success, and therefore the question as to whether the Yatra would succeed in getting the Congress to win the next elections was not appropriate. After all, none of the big nationwide movements fought under Gandhi ji's leadership—Non-Cooperation (1920–22), Civil Disobedience (1930–32) or Quit India (1942)—resulted in Independence. But they all contributed to it. They were not failures because they did not result in immediate independence. We also talked about how the BJY was most often compared to the Dandi Yatra, but a more appropriate comparison could be made with Gandhi's campaign in 1932–33 against discrimination against the so-called untouchables castes whom he called Harijans. For nine long months he was on the road, touring the whole country by walking, going by car and train and boat, village by village, arguing against untouchability, for permitting temple entry to Harijans and promoting interdining, which was prohibited. It was in its essence a campaign to unite Indians—'*Bharat jodo*'.